NITISH MAPS A PATH

The tenth-time CM's Samriddhi Yatra may be full of rhetoric on the past, but he's backing it up with an ambitious governance salvo to revive Bihar

By **Amitabh Srivastava**



FOR PROSPERITY Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar performs puja at Baba Bateshwar Nath Dham in Vaishali, Jan. 31

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THE VOTING WAS OVER IN EARLY NOVEMBER, and he won hands down, but Nitish Kumar still seems to be in campaign mode. A state-wide sojourn, sanguinely called 'Samriddhi Yatra' (Prosperity Tour), saw him in near-continuous movement for nine days, across nine districts of Bihar. And when the tenth-time chief minister took the mic in Vaishali on January 24, at the conclusion of this first phase, he was still invoking the past. Times when conditions were dire: when the streets emptied after dusk, conflict was a bullet away, roads patchy, electricity metered in flickers of hope, healthcare ailing, and schooling a lesson in 'how not to'.

So why does he look like a batsman intent on hitting sixes long after the match is over? It's a classic Nitish feint. He's actually playing a different match. Meanwhile, he clearly needs to play up while he negotiates a tricky phase in his record tenth term. Also, as a source of ongoing validation while he does that.

INTERNAL CONSOLIDATION

While Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav has said he will give the Nitish government a 100-day window before presenting his assessment, the CM is not retuning the favour. Instead, he continued in this vein during a three-day second phase of the yatra, winding through three more districts on January 27-29. So, what's the game?

Despite posting a remarkable recovery within the electoral sweep for the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA)—202 seats out of 243—Nitish's Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) is a notch lower than the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), at 85 seats versus 89. That meant a significant recalibration of power within his government. So, Nitish is finding ways to regirdle his authority.

Events in Patna tell the story. Right at the outset, Nitish had to cede the